Project Metamorphosis

Introduction

The foundation of the project is an individual investigation of consciousness (~10 years).

Structurally, the project consists of three documents arranged in sequence:

– "Report": a practical method and the phases of its application

– "Continuation": a view from a different angle

– "Choice": scaling

In addition to the three main documents, there are materials not included in the project. These materials are collected in "Field Notes," placed in the appendix.

The project is written in the third person about a "practitioner." Here, the practitioner is the material under investigation; the practitioner's individual traits are of no significance.

"Metamorphosis" is neither a scientific nor a pseudoscientific project. At the same time, it contains features of scientific form – terminology, structure, models. This is neither a claim to scientific status nor a decoration, but the use of available methods and tools.

The project asks nothing of the reader, offers no motivation and imposes no restrictions.

The project can be used as a tool for self-inquiry. The design and structure of such a tool are determined by the properties of the field of application. Whether the tool works can be tested through practical use. The result depends on the intensity of practice.

The practical method presented in the "Report" is neither the only correct method nor a fixed one. The described method can be modified and adapted to specific conditions. The method takes into account the characteristics and tendencies of the human mind.

Report

The document is a report on the practical activity that took place. The "Report" is divided into several parts – each is allocated for the description of phases of practice, which differ in characteristics and duration.

At the beginning of the "Report," a description of the practical method is presented – its application led to the creation of the project. The method is not constant but changes as it is applied – these changes will be mentioned in the report's chapters. The "Report" has a sequential structure, but chapters of varying density.

Practical method

On the origin of the method. Approximately two years before the beginning of the active phase of practice, a series of events occurred in the practitioner's life that radically shifted the balance of his self-understanding. This confluence of circumstances left no alternative but to begin the practice of self-inquiry.

The practitioner was not prepared: he possessed neither experience in self-inquiry nor any understanding of where to begin. Due to life circumstances, he had neither the strength nor the time to search for an effective technique (method). Therefore, the practitioner used what was at hand: he had once heard somewhere about the technique described in this document as point 2. That served as the start. The remaining parts of the practical method described here originated from point 2 as a result of trial and error.

The method consists of three parts: points 1-3, two rules, and technique #1. Each part of the practical method carries its own specific function, complementing the other parts in a particular way.

The intensity of executing the practical method. At the preliminary stages, it is experimentally established that large intervals between executions of the method bring no noticeable result. Executing the method for 20-30 minutes a day is like a formal checkmark "done" in a daily task list. Thus, the practitioner comes to the understanding that to achieve any tangible and explicit result, it is necessary to practice with all possible intensity. This means that practice (execution of the method) merges with everyday life and fills every possible minute. When this condition is met, the practitioner obtains the first explicit results. These results will be considered in the chapter "Active phase of practice" and beyond.

More about the practical method.

Point 1:

The practitioner looks at himself. He looks not into a mirror, but at himself with his inner gaze (that gaze with which the practitioner "sees" his thoughts and other content of consciousness). The practitioner shifts his attention so that he clearly understands: he is looking inside himself at something incomprehensible, and this "incomprehensible" is himself. This "incomprehensible" may be felt as a certain sharpness within or as a semblance of a center in consciousness. The practitioner isolates the direction of his inner gaze — only the direction is needed, not what is in the center. He does not attempt to find anything in consciousness and "glue" his gaze to it.

If the practitioner does not succeed in this, if something prevents him from determining the direction – in this case he turns to point 2.

If, however, the practitioner sees (notices, isolates) the direction, then point 2 is not needed, and he proceeds to point 3.

Point 2:

The practitioner directs his attention to that which usually fills consciousness as a background: to what is seen by the eyes, what is heard by the ears, what is felt by the body – to the sensory background. The content (background) itself, meanwhile, is of no importance. Only the effort that the practitioner applies to shift his attention to that which is usually filtered out and unnoticed is of importance.

Thus, the execution of point 2 consists in the practitioner literally looking at everything that is visible, listening to everything that is audible, and

feeling everything that is felt. He simply performs this with all possible attentiveness, without seeking meaning in it and without expecting anything.

The practitioner alternates between performing point 1 and point 2 for the precise (explicit) determination of the direction of his inner gaze (glance).

Point 3:

The practitioner has clearly noticed (determined) the direction of his inner gaze and therefore transitions from performing points 1-2 to point 3.

When performing point 3, the practitioner directs his inner gaze in the found direction and looks there. Soon he discovers that in that direction there is nothing visible, concrete, or of any other kind. In that direction, there is only complete indeterminacy.

The execution of point 3 contains no meaning and determinacy, and may be interpreted by the practitioner as not worth spending his energy on.

When performing point 3, the practitioner likewise (as before) does not engage in a search for meaning, does not wear himself out with the expectation of a result, but simply holds onto the direction he has found, directing all his attention there.

Rules of practice.

The rules are designed to aid the practitioner. They do not restrict but provide some determinacy where it is truly needed. The practitioner simply repeats them to himself when he gets distracted from the practice, when the focus of attention blurs, or when things get difficult.

There are two rules.

The main rule: begin and keep doing.

The other main rule: begin again and keep doing.

While performing points 1-3, the practitioner encounters various emerging interferences in his consciousness that hinder the search for or holding onto the found direction. The nature of these interferences will be examined in other chapters; here, the technique for their removal is described. In this project, the technique for removing interferences is named technique #1.

Technique #1 consists in the practitioner utilizing various situations from his life that trigger a noticeable (to the practitioner's attention) reaction. The necessity to apply technique #1 arises precisely at the moment when an interference has manifested in its fullness: the practitioner finds himself gripped by anger or condemnation, filled with resentment, experiencing guilt, envy, jealousy, shame, feeling greed, an irresistible craving for pleasure, absorbed by self-importance, or seized by a fit of irritation. All this and much else in the practitioner's consciousness is the starting signal for applying technique #1.

The first thing the practitioner realizes when he begins to observe these interferences in his consciousness is that they have a source – and this source is within the practitioner himself, not somewhere else.

Next, the practitioner begins carefully studying the manifested interference. To do this, the practitioner asks himself direct questions and searches for answers to them. The questions are roughly these: where did this come from? what exactly caused this within me? what is the root of this? The practitioner uses his honesty, searches within himself for truthful answers, and answers the posed direct questions for himself. The correct (true) answer is felt by the practitioner as a slight joy or lightness upon finding it – as if a certain

burden has been lifted. The practitioner studies and untangles the diverse causes and effects, intertwined in a tight knot, sorting out the structure of his personality, his "i".

Thus, technique #1 consists in the practitioner firmly seizing the thoughts and sensations hindering the performance of points 1-3, carefully investigating them all the way to their very source. He isolates the interference and pulls on it as if pulling a thread that leads into the impenetrable depths of consciousness, drawing it out into the light until the very end.

The practitioner's honesty serves as the guarantee of the effectiveness of technique #1. Using it 100%, the practitioner reaches the origin of all interferences in his consciousness.

Technique #1 is universal; the practitioner uses it both for a current situation and for situations from the past that have left a trace in his memory.

Points 1-3, technique #1, and the rules of practice complement each other, while performing different functions. Through performing points 1-3, the practitioner finds the direction; technique #1 gives the practitioner a semblance of forward movement in the found direction; the rules of practice are needed when the practitioner is left without support and does not know how to proceed further (which happens very often).

In the active phase of practice, the practitioner applies points 1-3 whenever it is at all possible, without separating practice and life. The application of technique #1 is episodic – when the practitioner's attention notices an interference, he already knows what needs to be done. The rules of practice, once the practitioner has memorized and uses them, help him time and again to return to the execution of the practical method.

Active phase of practice

The beginning of practice coincides with the beginning of its active phase. The start of practice is considered to be the moment when the practitioner notices the first explicit result of his efforts. The appearance of a result means that changes have occurred with the practitioner.

The application of technique #1 prior to the start of the active phase honed the practitioner's honesty, and now the practitioner assesses what he notices in his consciousness with sufficient sobriety.

The practitioner's honed honesty, which has yielded real results, is the sole criterion of truth available to him. No other criteria – books, authoritative or other opinions, various concepts, speculations, and the like – will come to his aid, will not provide him with a point of support, will not tell him whether he is going in the right direction. The practitioner can lean only on his own honesty.

The practitioner does not use the practice to achieve anything, does not expend energy on conforming to something, does not compete with anyone, and does not try to prove anything. The practitioner applies points 1-3 and technique #1 without the goal of obtaining anything in return (benefit).

The first real result of the practitioner's efforts is expressed in the fact that thoughts and images noticeably change their properties, and the space where they replace one another slightly expands.

Thoughts and images slightly lose their color (fading like fabric in the sun), become less dense, and their "volume" decreases. This change in the properties of thoughts leads to a reduction in their impact on the practitioner's attention – the attention gradually frees itself from the pressure of thoughts and other content of consciousness.

In the process of practice, it is discovered that technique #1 has a significant impact on the content of thoughts, while the performance of points 1-3 influences their properties to a greater degree. Initially, the content of the practitioner's thoughts does not change, but a change in their properties occurs.

Almost immediately after the start of the active phase, it is discovered that the application of technique #1 entails the emergence of an effect named here "rollback". This effect also occurs from applying points 1-3, but to a lesser extent, less explicitly and intensely than from technique #1.

The practitioner sees that after he finds a deep answer (i.e., "gets to the bottom" of a particular interference's root), his thoughts fade a bit more, lose "density," and always after that a "rollback" occurs.

The "rollback" effect manifests as the practitioner feeling powerlessness, fear, and hopelessness for several days in a row. He experimentally establishes that the duration and intensity of the "rollback" directly depend on the depth of the answer he has found – the deeper the practitioner delves into himself, the more profound the layers he untangles and illuminates with his attention, the more intense the "rollback".

Locating and illuminating the deepest layers of the "i" with attention causes significant and prolonged "rollbacks". Such "rollbacks" are felt differently and are akin to "dark nights", completely enveloping the practitioner. They last up to several weeks and are accompanied by severely experienced physical suffering.

The practitioner is partly prepared for such a turn of events: the multiple "rollbacks" have taught him not to lose his head, not to try to do something to alleviate his condition – attempts to ease it only worsened the suffering he was experiencing. The practitioner learned from his own experience that the only effective way to get through suffering is to endure it honestly and fully. Thus, "rollbacks" and "dark nights" are an integral part of the practice for the practitioner, not a reason to drop out at the very start.

Gradually, having gained sufficient experience, the practitioner understands that living through all these unpleasant moments is living through oneself, one's essence. Honest and complete living through of the deep layers of the "i" deprives them of their influence on the practitioner and leads to their complete "dissolution". The mechanism of "dissolution" itself will be examined later in the report; this mechanism is one of the key processes of the practice.

At a certain stage of the active phase, the practitioner lives through himself to such a depth that he directly approaches the source of self-pity.

This source is perceived by the practitioner as something resembling a lake filled with a viscous black liquid. The practitioner sees that the "lake" is filled with fear.

Having studied the "lake," the practitioner understands that before him is a boundary layer of his own nature. This layer surrounds and guards him, creating the boundaries of his "i," separating "mine/internal" from "other/external." The practitioner tries to find some safe way around it, without disturbing or touching it. He tries different methods but soon realizes that the only way to overcome this layer is to dive into it headfirst.

The practitioner is tempered by the "dark nights" and other unpleasant effects, but standing before this "lake," he understands that the true unknown lies ahead. This places the practitioner before a difficult choice, where on one side of the scale is he himself with all that he has, all that he carefully preserves and is ready to do anything for, and on the other side is nothing: indeterminacy and primal fear. The complexity of the choice lies in its irreversibility: a choice must be made, only one option can be chosen only once, and it will not be possible to return and "re-choose."

Standing there before this "lake," reviewing within himself everything that can be reviewed in search of a hint for the right decision, the practitioner clearly and distinctly understands that he has found no hint and is unlikely to find any; nothing will help him make this important and difficult decision. Then he remembers the direction that led him to the shore of this black "lake." He finds it and, without hesitation, follows where it points – he dives headfirst into the viscous, primal fear.

When the practitioner passes through the boundary layer of his nature, he sees that the "lake" is no more.

Soon after passing through the boundary layer, the practitioner notices the changes that have occurred in him. Everything that previously held value for the practitioner becomes empty for him. The changes also concern sexual attraction: any interaction between a man and a woman becomes a matter of complete indifference to the practitioner.

Instead of thoughts, the practitioner now observes movements in consciousness, resembling fast, light "breezes." The practitioner uses them for solving everyday tasks, without delving into the mechanism of their operation.

Next, the practitioner notices the presence of an urge-driven activity in consciousness – that activity which seeks an outlet (realization) through action, seeking, and other affairs that constitute the practitioner's life.

The continuation of practice leads to this noticed urge-driven activity gradually fading — "doing" becomes "non-doing," and liberation from the need to do anything occurs.

At times, the practitioner is visited by "rollbacks". At this stage of the active phase, they become a rare, residual phenomenon, lasting a few hours and perceived as disorientation, fatigue, or a viscosity of the mind.

Further application of points 1-3 and technique #1 leads to the practitioner's thoughts undergoing even greater changes: the fast, light movements in consciousness diminish ("dry up") and become almost indistinguishable from the noise of blood flowing in the practitioner's body – thoughts become akin to a rustle or a faintly audible noise. Attention is almost completely freed from "internal" pressure, becomes a precise and reliable tool. When necessary, attention makes use of this "rustle" (turns to it), which was once dense, heavy thoughts, for solving certain tasks from life and other simple activities.

The next stage is the concluding stage for this phase.

At this stage, the practitioner feels objects and phenomena as if they are inside him and made of him. This is perceived as a felt geometry in consciousness, somewhat like how a candy is felt in the mouth – from all sides, structurally. The practitioner's mind becomes empty and clear, perception gains depth, as if another set of eyes opens within.

Here, the unification of points 1-3 and technique #1 also occurs.

The unification happens as a result of the appearance of an unusual phenomenon in the practitioner's consciousness. This phenomenon is a light that the practitioner notices in consciousness.

The practitioner investigates this phenomenon, its properties, and finds that this phenomenon (the light) requires no maintenance – it is literally and unconditionally present in the practitioner's field of perception. The light has no source, it is indifferent to everything, one cannot get used to it, it is unchanging, homogeneous and soft, always the same, completely stable and constant. Appearing in the body-consciousness, the light concludes the movements of the mind, rendering it motionless. Initially, the light is bluish-white; it spreads through the practitioner, rising from the bottom up. The appearance of this phenomenon is accompanied by the body fully relaxing, all tensions are released; an unusual, soft sensation arises in the body-consciousness, which is difficult to describe due to its simplicity and depth.

The appearance of the soft, indifferent light in consciousness is the concluding stage of the active phase of practice.

The active phase is the most eventful and rich in various effects; it is also the longest of the three described in this document. It has the maximum impact on the practitioner's daily life.

Some features of the active phase.

Before the start of the active phase, life provided the practitioner with hints, hinted at something, closed one door and opened another. After the active phase ends, this no longer happens and never will again – life leaves the practitioner alone, precisely as he is. Everything is significantly simplified; the practitioner falls out of many systems and communities of human life, finds himself on the sidelines of this world. The previous way of life, accumulated values, people, connections, and everything else that previously constituted the practitioner's life – all of this remains in the past. The practitioner is deprived of any protection.

There is no beneficiary in what the practitioner does.

Formless phase of practice

The flow of practice differs in each of its phases. At the very beginning, despite the "dark nights," "rollbacks," and other difficult moments, the practice flows quite actively. The practitioner's strength is periodically replenished when a layer of the "i" is found and "dissolved" – strength is no longer spent on maintaining that layer. All this imparts an active flow to the practice.

The active phase ends when nothing remains in consciousness that can be defined by the mind. Throughout the active phase of practice, the value of things is lost, meaning is lost, no solid ground remains underfoot, the previous life irrevocably concludes. Further, practice transitions into the formless phase.

The unification of points 1-3 and technique #1 occurs soon after the light has manifested in the practitioner's consciousness. These events – the manifestation of light and the unification – are interconnected, do not occur in isolation from each other and are that conditional boundary which separates the active and formless phases. The diverse effects of the active phase conclude and do not manifest further.

Observing and studying the light, the practitioner discovers that the light has the property of revealing those "places" in the body-consciousness where remnants of his "i" still persist. The revelation occurs as the light rises in body-consciousness – rising from the bottom up, the light encounters obstacles on its path and concentrates there, revealing and illuminating them. What was previously invisible becomes visible in this phase of practice.

The tendency of the light (its observed behavior) – to gradually fill the body-consciousness – is perceived by the practitioner as a given, as the natural flow of practice. Observing this tendency of the light to fill body-consciousness, the practitioner understands that the obstacles hindering this natural process must be eliminated. The concentration of light in specific places of the body-consciousness indicates to the practitioner what needs to be examined.

An obstacle that prevents the light from rising further cannot be eliminated by technique #1 in its former (pre-unification) form – nothing remains in consciousness that has a form definable by the mind. The obstacle is eliminated by living through it and patience. The process of eliminating an obstacle is similar to observing a small islet during high tide: the water gradually rises, the islet becomes smaller and smaller until it disappears entirely. If the practitioner does not observe the islet-obstacle, the "flooding" of the islet does not occur.

At one of the stages of the formless phase, the practitioner notices that the rising of the light in the body-consciousness proportionally expands understanding.

Here, "understanding" is literally the volume of consciousness that the practitioner sees and is aware of; understanding is a direct consequence of living through. What is lived through is transformed into understanding (into a volume of consciousness).

At this stage, the practitioner understands that the multi-layered mechanism of his "i" is something like a filter (i-filter). The filter divides the universal flow of life and allows through only those streams which correspond to its individual configuration and can pass through the intricate weave of the filter.

Individual streams of the universal flow of life, having passed through the filter, create the individual spectrum of life. In this spectrum, some parts of the universal flow of life are present in different proportions and combinations, but not the entire flow. This unique spectrum is lived by the practitioner and constitutes for him the only real reality.

The execution of the practical method led to the mechanism of the "i" being gradually, layer by layer, "dissolved" – filtration ceases.

The practitioner understands that the light which has manifested and gradually fills the body-consciousness is the natural perception, not filtering the flow of life. The practitioner finds nothing unusual or extraordinary in such perception.

Here, "natural" means eventfulness undistorted by intervention, unfiltered.

At this stage, the practitioner understands the process that produces the "dissolution" of the i-filter – it is a process of transforming one thing into another. Transformation is the key process of the entire practice; it occurs throughout its entire duration, at different scales.

Everything the practitioner has at his disposal – his available resource – is already initially present "on board" and concentrated in the form of the i-filter. Such a "concentrate" is similar to chemical fuel, for example, coal. Under certain conditions (combustion), the concentrate is again transformed back into its primary state from which it was once born. Fear, suffering, despair – the binding substance, released as products of "combustion" (smoke) in the process of transformation. Transformation (combustion) occurs through the awareness and complete living through of the layers of the i-filter.

Thus, through practice, the reverse transformation of the i-filter occurs with the release of that primary state from which the i-filter was once born.

The practitioner sees that the reverse transformation of the i-filter leads to a deepening of understanding, to an expansion (of volume) of consciousness. He understands that the primary state of the i-filter is consciousness; it is released during the reverse transformation of the filter.

Other methods and strategies of interacting with the i-filter do not lead to transformation: avoiding the living through of the layers of the "i" strengthens the filter, increasing its stability.

The continuation of practice leads to the obstacles on the path of the filling light being transformed into light.

The practitioner understands the nature of the light – it is consciousness devoid of artifacts, its primary, empty original form.

Here, "artifacts" literally means formations in consciousness consisting of consciousness in a "solid" aggregate state, like ice floating in water.

Previously, the practitioner perceived the initial form of consciousness as light because areas containing artifacts were still present in it, and relative to these "dark" areas the empty initial state of consciousness was perceived as light.

The function of the i-filter in the practice of self-inquiry: the i-filter develops and grows, accumulating mass. When the mass reaches a critical magnitude, the filter loses stability and balances on the edge of collapse. The loss of stability initiates the practice of self-inquiry; the i-filter becomes the fuel of the practice.

The transformation (living through) of the entire complex structure of the i-filter gives a direct understanding of its structure and origin.

Very deep layers of the "i" structure have peculiarities and are difficult to understand (they are closely connected with the body). These layers are not dark but thin and almost transparent, barely discernible. These layers have no relation to the practitioner's life but were inherited by him and became the foundation of the "i" structure. Studying these inherited layers, the practitioner discovers that the formation of the i-filter and the accumulation of its mass began long before his birth.

The practitioner sees and lives through the echo of distant events contained in the layers he inherited. Having lived through them, he understands the causes that became the foundation of the current situation. Studying these layers brings much into perspective and makes it possible to avoid going in circles, repeating the same thing from cycle to cycle.

Thus, "the accumulation of mass" is the accumulation of "heavy" layers in consciousness, with their subsequent conversion into a starting configuration for the next, more complex and massive i-filter; accumulation is part of the mechanism of inheritance.

"Heavy" layers consist of fear and its derivatives. Fear is the means of accumulating and increasing the mass of the i-filter.

At this point lies the conditional boundary between the formless phase and the completion phase.

The formless phase of practice is not as saturated with events or phenomena as the previous one. However, in its course, the practitioner undergoes significant changes. Such changes affect the practitioner's mode of perception, turning it from "sequential" into "parallel".

Here, "parallel mode of perception" is a process of perception that has no "reference point" (origin of coordinates); the absence of distance and other distinctions between the perceiver and the perceived.

By the end of the formless phase, the practitioner is filled with the light of consciousness without artifacts. The practitioner understands the nature of the light and its origin.

At the end of the formless phase, the execution of the practical method (after unification) is transformed once again. An inversion occurs: what previously required directed effort becomes everyday life.

What follows is a simplified schematic sketch of what the practitioner sees and understands. It is not the construction of a cosmological model: the sketch serves as a signpost and a connecting link in the narrative. The sketch is an interpretation (a likeness), condensed just enough to remain expedient.

At the bottom of the sketch, at its foundation, lies potential.

Here, “potential” is possibility, capability; it is literally the not_happened.

For the sake of simplicity, within the sketch “potential” and “space” are not distinguished and are treated as one: potential is space.

Potential is symmetrical with itself (it has no second pole and is non-relative) and has no limitations: there are no parts, no internal structure. Therefore, the natural, original state of potential is non-realization: potential contains nothing within itself, while simultaneously having the possibility to contain everything without exception.

Because of this symmetry (completeness) and the possibility of containing everything, potential also contains the capability to realize this possibility (to contain everything).

The realization of potential occurs for an indeterminate reason. Such a reason does not appear from outside and is not born of external processes; it is already contained within the potential (the capability for realization). This reason is “ideal”: it realizes the potential completely, without delay, without phases of development, instantaneously.

The realization of potential has no reason other than a chance one.

Here, "chance" means an event that has determinately occurred but has no other determinacy: no cause, no dimensions, no coordinates.

The realization of potential occurs in a single instant, having no duration. In this instant, something like a "bouquet" arises – the potential of space is unfolded by this "bouquet" of absolutely all possible properties, variants, and combinations.

Here, "bouquet" is a necessary image for the sketch, representing the "form" and content of the realized potential of space.

The unfolded "bouquet" of properties is a self-sustaining "construction" and is structured such that every one of its internal properties exists only because other properties are present in the "bouquet" that support it, and it supports them. All properties of the "bouquet" are interconnected, do not exist isolated from each other (independently), but only together, instantaneously.

"Properties" are the properties of potential (space), distributed at the moment of its realization from the simplest to the most complex; such properties include spatial metrics, all possible types of interaction and natural constants (boundaries or laws) – all of this is distributed layer by layer in this sketch from the bottom to the top, where each layer is formed by properties of a certain complexity and is the basis for the subsequent layer with even more complex properties – a gradient of complexity of properties.

The practitioner understands that the absence of independent existence of the properties (separate from the "bouquet") is the reason that processes born from such properties are also relative and interdependent. At the same time, there is no other process of which the realized "bouquet" of properties would be a part – the "bouquet" is non-relative.

The sketch describes the "bouquet" as a certain construction of layers of property complexity, having "height". In what the practitioner sees, there is no "height" – any such layer of properties literally has no thickness, being simultaneously both a boundary and the area which it divides. What is shown as a vertical distribution of complexity of properties (the gradient) is more accurately defined as the nesting of some properties within others. However, describing this nesting implies an increase in dimensionality, which would noticeably complicate the entire sketch, making it redundant.

Thus, in this sketch, the "bouquet" is the vertical connecting link between the bottom and the top.

At the top of the sketch is an area that the practitioner perceives as maximally complex, entirely consisting of all possible realized properties of space. This is the area where the maximum concentration of complexity has manifested another property of space – consciousness.

Here, "consciousness" is literally the fully realized potential of space; a process without component parts, continuously (non-discretely) knowing itself.

Consciousness is not limited to the uppermost and most complex area, where it realized itself fully (at the limit of concentration). One could say that here consciousness is like a searchlight that shines from the top of the drawing to its very bottom. As one approaches the foundation (towards potential), the intensity of the searchlight's light decreases to the same degree as the complexity of properties in the layers of the "bouquet" decreases. Consciousness is the entire "bouquet". Therefore, despite the fact that in this sketch consciousness is located at the very top, it is, nevertheless, present throughout the entire "height" of the "bouquet" of properties. The light of consciousness does not reach the foundation (the potential) – consciousness cannot illuminate that which has not happened.

Completion phase of practice

The beginning of the completion phase is chosen as the conditional moment when the practitioner sees the original picture (the basis of the sketch) and understands that the realization of potential in no way exhausts it. Realization gives birth to the entire system (the "bouquet"), where on one "side" lies the unrealized, and on the other the fully realized potential. The movement that inevitably arises between these "sides" as a potential difference is consciousness.

Thus, seeing the original picture, the practitioner understands the relative nature of consciousness.

At this point, the schematic sketch from the chapter “Formless phase of practice” has fulfilled its function, having indicated the nature of consciousness. In itself, the sketch has no significance.

The practitioner's understanding of the relative nature of the process "consciousness" occurs instantaneously. Such understanding is continuous (non-discrete) and does not create a boundary dividing the practitioner's understanding into "before" and "after." Instantaneity is not a certain point, pointing to which the practitioner could say: "it appeared right here, and before that it was not."

The practitioner's understanding of the relative nature of consciousness is not a mystery revealed by the practitioner and not a reward for his efforts; it is like remembering what is already known but forgotten.

The understanding of the relative nature of consciousness leads the practitioner to the study of the properties of reality.

Here, "reality" is the moment or "place" where the not_happened becomes the happened; the conditional "place" where the loss of indeterminacy occurs.

Turning to the moment of realization of potential, the practitioner sees a certain gap separating the happened from the not_happened (potential).

Studying the gap, the practitioner understands that the gap has neither dimensions nor coordinates – the gap is indeterminate, immeasurable and unidirectional (irreversible). The gap is truly random; indeterminacy is its fundamental property. From the gap emanates the light of consciousness.

The gap is reality.

Previously, when the practitioner saw how the properties of thoughts change, he lost belief in them: thoughts turned out to be not an islet of stability but temporary phenomena. Exactly the same happened with the practitioner's "i". Now, seeing reality, he knows nothing about what he sees: in reality there is nothing that can be seen, understood, and remembered. The perception of reality (indeterminacy) has explicit consequences: the division into "past-present-future" is lost. Everything that was previously "real" now becomes already happened – an echo coming from reality.

"The happened" is that which has lost indeterminacy and acquired determinacy; the happened emanates from reality, like a wave from a source of disturbance, but is not reality itself; the happened is relatively real.

The practitioner understands that he had never before seen reality – it was closed off from him by the i-filter. His attention was turned entirely toward the shadow zone created by the filter, and his understanding was limited to this shadow zone. Within that zone, complex, shifting interference patterns formed from those separate streams of the universal flow (emanating from

reality) that had passed through the filter. The practitioner's understanding interpreted this complex and unique interplay of light and shadow as "i" and "my life". The interplay of light and shadow was real and fully determinate for the practitioner.

Since then, much has changed. Now the practitioner understands that any determinacy does not possess independent reality. Determinacy is an illusion creating "reality" within itself — a frame imposed on indeterminacy.

Further, the practitioner discovers that the very fact of the gap's (reality's) existence is a random asymmetry, which occurred as the difference between realized and unrealized potential of space. This difference generates a force (an observed tendency), which manifests itself as a striving toward the elimination of the asymmetry. The force (tendency) is manifested in the fact that everything realized from the potential of space strives toward the elimination of the difference and a return to the original balanced, unrealized "form".

The return to the original "form" can be accomplished only upon the full exhaustion of the difference between the realized and unrealized potential. The exhaustion of the difference occurs in the process of self-inquiry through transformation and, as a consequence, completion.

After the discovery of the force (tendency), further practice proceeds on the basis of the practitioner's hypothetical assumption (hypothesis). The hypothesis is based on the properties of consciousness already studied and on the absence of a more plausible and verifiable alternative interpretation.

In the practitioner's understanding, the world where he appeared is a process of eliminating asymmetry (a striving toward original symmetry), which arose as a chance spark in the unrealized potential. The practitioner himself is a local node of a complex pattern of many different relative processes within the resulting asymmetry.

The practitioner has discovered that consciousness simultaneously possesses relative (dynamic) and non-relative (motionless) properties. Such a "blend" manifests itself as movement without a mover, perception without a perceiver (subject). "Movement" and "perception" occur relative to the source – reality. Thus, consciousness is not detached from reality (very close to reality), and at the same time is loaded with relative properties.

The practitioner has repeatedly lived through the "dissolution" of artifact layers – both late and early ones. This led to the understanding that consciousness contains only consciousness – it is like a mechanism that uses itself (its "body") to create complex constructions (artifacts) within itself. This mechanism is reversible: consciousness is capable of transforming the resulting constructions back into its "body." The reverse transformation completes the processes constituting the artifacts, leaving at the output formless consciousness.

Creation and completion are not two separate mechanisms, but a single one operating in opposite directions.

Reversibility here is the invariance of the unified mechanism of creation and completion relative to reality. Only the scale and direction (sign) change; the mechanism itself remains the same.

The hypothesis is this: self-completion. In the limit, the reversibility of consciousness is applicable to consciousness itself, as a process. Having discovered itself, consciousness is capable of completing the relative (dynamic) part of itself – movement and perception. Completion will relieve

consciousness of the load of relative properties. What remains is the "motionless" non-relative part of the "blend," which means the loss of determinacy. The loss of determinacy means a "return" to the symmetry of unrealized potential.

The hypothesis of self-completion is an extrapolation of the operating principle of technique #1 to its ultimate scale. The loss of determinacy (completion) has exactly the same mechanics as in the smaller-scale case of investigating interferences during the execution of points 1-3. Consciousness needs nothing, having everything necessary "on board": a symmetrical mechanism of creation and completion.

The practitioner understands that the body and the i-filter are of the same nature and are necessary conditions of practice. The difference consists in the fact that the body is an echo of very distant events; it is adapted and stable (homeostasis). Whereas the i-filter consists of relatively "fresh" (young) layers. Such layers are sufficiently easily subject to reverse transformation into consciousness.

The practitioner sees that the body is filled with pure (conditionally) consciousness and is the final "frontier," creating separateness. Verification of the hypothesis is possible only after the loss of the physical body. The nature of the hypothesis is such that it cannot be verified and included in the report. The loss of the physical body is the event horizon of life.

In this report, the hypothesis is present because, on its basis, the practitioner continues practice-life until its natural completion.

The continuation of practice occurs in such a way as not to delay the moment of testing the hypothesis, but also not to strive for it.

End of report

Continuation

Understanding is a nonlinear and voluminous process. Describing such a process requires several points of view – several projections or orthogonal models.

In the "Report," a sequential practical experience is presented – a vertical projection of the process of understanding. The "Continuation" is a view from a different angle – a horizontal description of the same process, a view "from above." The "Continuation" aims to rid the "Report" of distortion and one-sidedness.

* * *

Having advanced in the practice, the practitioner discovers that the practice is akin to a fractal, where the small fully repeats the large. Each stage has its own properties, yet the principle of how the processes are structured does not change. The practitioner sees that in space there is only space, and nothing else. He sees self-similarity.

Recursive nesting allows one to know the large through knowing the small. The practitioner sees and comprehends the absence of size and scale, the absence of center and periphery, the absence of any hierarchy.

Having completed a full cycle of the practice (a complete fractal pattern), the practitioner understands that there is no determinacy: neither the practitioner himself, nor any of his constituents have independent existence and are but a single relative process. Such a unified process cannot be given any clear and precise definition; it manifests itself in a multitude of other interdependent processes. This process has almost no determinacy: no form, no coordinates, no dimensions. Like any relative process, it has direction and properties.

This formless (not fully determinate) process can conditionally be called "direct and unconditional knowledge of itself" or consciousness.

The process "consciousness" begins in a certain immeasurable and indefinable "place," which can conditionally be called "reality." Despite its direct connection with reality, the process "consciousness" is real only relatively, and in itself (apart from reality) has no independent existence. The process "consciousness" is like a wave emanating from reality and consisting only of itself.

The cycle of the process "consciousness" begins in reality and ends there as well.

The beginning of the cycle is the acquisition of a certain determinacy. The process "consciousness" is almost entirely formless, and its acquired determinacy (its property) consists only in the fact that this process knows itself. This determinacy makes the process "consciousness" relative.

The acquisition of determinacy occurs upon exiting reality. Reality is the "place" where the not_happened becomes the happened, acquires properties (determinacy). Such acquired properties are interdependent – they support each other and do not exist separately. From these properties, features, and their combinations, everything that constitutes the practitioner himself and the vast surrounding world is born.

The end of the cycle is the loss of determinacy, the loss of properties. At this point, consciousness ceases to be a process: it does not leave reality, does not exit it, does not acquire determinacy. Movement ceases.

Depending on the phase, the practice of self-inquiry looks very different. Each phase has its own quite definite sets of features and properties. Advancement in the practice simplifies these sets; the practitioner gradually loses determinacy as such.

The process of transformation is difficult; it promises nothing but indeterminacy and deprivation: the consolation prize of happiness, peace, and bliss is absent.

The necessity of help is embedded in the very structure of being. The continuation of practice consists in helping living beings (including humans) in one way or another. The practitioner understands the words "help" and "compassion" differently. He has no ability to feel compassion; the practitioner has lost such a mechanism.

The absence of compassionate mechanisms in the practitioner changes the nature of help – it becomes impersonal and non-addressed. But even such help is a highly ambiguous affair; it will most likely yield no noticeable results and can look like anything.

The practitioner does not compete, does not prove, admits no benefit of any kind, and neither expects nor avoids anything. The practitioner is the vector of the least necessary action. Practice becomes life.

The most effective thing the practitioner can do is to continue the practice until its natural completion. The predispositions, skills, and abilities that the practitioner still has assist in this matter, lending the practice individual features.

Choice

The practitioner is not detached from the conditions in which his practice began and proceeded. The practitioner is an ordinary person, a typical representative of his biological species, living within society. The difference lies in superficial individual traits and features, with an identical load-bearing structure.

Self-inquiry began as an attempt to emerge from a severe crisis, which almost became the final chapter of the practitioner's life. Having conducted a multi-year practical investigation of his own nature, he learned what he is "made of" and on what foundation his "i" rested.

The "black lake," described in the "Report," is the boundary layer guarding and separating the individual "i" from the universal flow of life.

Standing before the "lake," the practitioner was faced with a decisive choice. He understood that retreating back would change nothing, would not eliminate the cause of the crisis – inevitably he would return to the choice once more. But he would return already under different conditions – exhausted and cornered. And that is the best outcome, for the next such crisis could indeed become the final one.

The practitioner made his decision and continued self-inquiry.

Continuing was extremely terrifying. Fear was everywhere; it was dense like a liquid. Until that moment, the practitioner had never felt fear of such density.

It soon became apparent that immersion in the "black lake" was not fatal: the fear was dreadful, but not poisonous; it menaced, but did not wound. The essence of fear became visible: a living defenselessness, blindly and unconsciously striving to protect itself. The practitioner saw this, and the fear dissolved like morning mist. Nothing threatened life; the practitioner's understanding had moved beyond its former boundaries.

Overcoming the boundary layer became a kind of decisive fork in the road. On one side of this fork lay the previous life, a return to which required no effort. This option was simple and obvious. On the other side of the fork was frightening indeterminacy.

At the moment of making the choice, everything was at stake: the practitioner's life, all that was dear and beloved to him, all that he carefully preserved and for which he was prepared to do anything. At the same time, the continuation of self-inquiry contained within it the potential possibility of overcoming the crisis and not returning to it again and again.

Having investigated himself, the practitioner understood the cause of the crisis, understood why it could not be resolved by less radical measures. The cause of the crisis lay in the very foundation of the practitioner's "i"; his entire life was built upon this foundation; all of the practitioner's actions contained this foundation, originating from it. The cause lay in the fundamental structure of the practitioner himself, in the very first brick of the intricate construction of the "i" – in fear.

Having studied it, the practitioner understood that fear is not an error or an enemy. Without it, life itself could hardly take place: life is defenseless and fragile; it strives to take root in an unknown world, overcoming the shock of birth and the initial difficulties.

Fear is a survival defense mechanism, but its expediency is limited. Fear becomes an impediment when the difficulties are overcome. The "cocoon" becomes constricting but continues to perform its functions, working equally in both directions: it protects from the world "outside," while simultaneously preventing understanding from breaking through the "cocoon" from within.

In the case of the practitioner, the way out of the crisis was not the reinforcement of boundaries but their overcoming: to investigate one's own nature, find the boundaries, and step into the unknown. Overcoming fear opened the space that lies on the other side of the "i" cocoon. The process of metamorphosis.

The practitioner sees in people the same thing he saw in himself: at the foundation lies a self-preservation mechanism – the "i" is built on fear.

Fear is the basic mechanism, applied as a criterion of truth within a human's self-enclosed frame of reference. This state of affairs has turned this mechanism into a life strategy adopted "by default."

Progress and achievements have not led to a change in the basic settings of the human, have not rid humanity of crises and suffering. Replacing "bad" with "good" and "old" with "new" addresses the consequences without affecting the cause.

The crisis is a direct consequence of the "i" structure having reached a critical mass, being unable to sustain itself, and standing at the limit of its stability.

* * *

The first path: to continue living the same life. Nothing needs to be undertaken; this is the obvious "default" path.

The second path: to try to engage in self-inquiry – to turn directly to the cause of the crisis and investigate it. A difficult path, with no guarantee of success.

Both paths are equally legitimate; they are phases of a single process, like inhaling and exhaling. At the same time, they are oppositely directed, and it is not possible to follow both paths at once; compromise is absent due to the properties of the cause of the crisis. The opposite directions of the paths lead to different consequences.

The first is the path of accumulation.

The second is the path of transforming the accumulated.

Choice is not about choosing within the confines of the "cocoon." Here, choice is not a ratio of benefit and discomfort, not a moral category, and not an act of will, but a mode of self-regulation in the process of life: whether the possibility for accumulation remains or the time has come to exhale.

Project Metamorphosis only makes this choice visible.

The main difference between the paths lies in their foundation. The foundation of the first path remains untouched – it is fear. The second path proceeds from honesty.

Honesty is the absence of fear.

End of project

Appendix

Field Notes

Collected here are some notes, observations, and other materials not included in Project Metamorphosis. The chronology is non-linear and at times mixed.

* * *

The indeterminate nature of being is perceived by the mind as emptiness or, in other words, as indeterminacy.

A mind not yet fully inquired into cannot be empty – abiding in indeterminacy is unbearable; it is pure meaninglessness. Such a mind avoids indeterminacy by filling the emptiness with activity: defining itself as someone or something, playing roles, generating judgments, meanings, and concepts.

Reactive, void-filling activity is a consequence of the unconscious (unlived) content of consciousness. The practice of self-inquiry is aimed at revealing this content and illuminating it with the light of consciousness. The hidden content is lived through, activity ceases. Indeterminacy remains.

* * *

At a certain stage, the practitioner recognizes himself as a kind of laminar flow (process), passing through him and simultaneously being him. This flow is consciousness.

Having studied the properties of the flow and the "place" from which it originates, the practitioner discovers a change in the mode of perception: the distance between the observer and the observed disappears. Deprived of its usual coordinate system, thinking undergoes a "shift." Such a mode of perception can be called "parallel" or "immediate."

Immediate perception occurs as the simultaneous perception of two "layers." The first "layer" (mundane or sensory) is the awareness of the seen/heard and other felt phenomena; the second layer is the perception of indeterminacy (reality).

These two "layers" are perceived simultaneously, without interfering with each other – the "layers" are nested within each other.

The perception of reality is accompanied by the suspension of memory and mind. In indeterminacy, there is nothing for the mind to notice, nor for memory to retain – in that "area," mind and memory cannot perform their functions.

Due to the nested nature of the "layers," the practitioner understands the very fact of looking into reality. However, this understanding does not allow one to remember the "content" of reality.

In the early stages of such dual perception, lapses in memory occur. Most often, the practitioner does not remember what happened a minute or an hour ago, does not

make plans, for he simply forgets them. The clarity and depth of perception itself, meanwhile, do not change, but peculiarities in memory function are observed.

Gradually, the practitioner adapts; the overlapping of the "layers" ceases – their mutual fusion occurs. This leads to the simultaneous perception of both "layers." Such perception is not fragmentary, requires no effort, and becomes everyday.

The first sensory "layer" occupies a secondary place and is perceived as translucent: distinctly but detachedly, like an incorporeal echo of what has already happened. This "layer" is "interpretation." Interpretation occurs within the boundaries of the practitioner's body.

The second "layer" is devoid of any properties. This is what can conditionally be called reality. The perception of the second "layer" is not "practical experience" in the usual sense; it is unconditional indeterminacy. The first "layer" (the echo) emanates from the second – from reality.

Such dual perception is always "fresh," unburdened by the "past" and not directed toward the "future"; duration and accumulation are absent.

Here, the "freshness" of perception is aptly described as the inertia of the perception process itself. Initially, before the fusion of the "layers," the inertia is significant – perception "lags behind" reality, taking its own delay for the "solidity" and determinacy of being. As practice progresses, as the i-filter thins and the inertia decreases, the "layers" gradually converge until they fuse – the delay disappears. Perception becomes inertialess and instantaneous.

One cannot say that these two "layers" are one thing. At the same time, one cannot say they are separate – no "layer" exists as something independent. Any attempt to positively define the nature of the "layers" will be false.

The first "layer" of perception is determinately nothing; the second "layer" is indeterminately nothing. Here lies the boundary of language's capabilities. Beyond this, there are no words.

Direct perception of reality occurs in the direction that the practitioner found while executing points 1-2 and maintained through point 3 (the practical method).

In immediate perception, distance is absent: the observer and the observed merge. Practice continues as abiding in indeterminacy.

The division into layers of perception is conditional and has no relation to ontology. The properties of the "layers" are investigated through direct experience, and the division into "primary/secondary" arises as an unavoidable interpretation of experience when writing notes.

* * *

Properties of thoughts. Here, the category of "thought" extends to diverse reactive and background activity in consciousness: thoughts, the inner voice, images, sensations, emotional responses, the background coloring of sensory information, urge-driven impulses.

In the course of practice, thoughts significantly change their properties: the intensity of their impact on attention, their "volume," their "density."

At the very beginning of the active phase of practice, the "volume" of every thought was approximately equal to that of normal conversation; the "density" and texture were akin to dense felt; the degree of impact was near maximum. An arising thought was accepted unconditionally, was a stable and temporally invariant phenomenon: the content could change, but the belief in the "solid" nature of the phenomenon remained unchanged. Not even a shadow of suspicion arose that the properties of thoughts were not constant.

The starting point of the practice of self-inquiry is chosen as the moment when a noticeable change in the properties of thought occurs. The properties change simultaneously in all thoughts, regardless of their content. When the practitioner notices the change in properties of what had been a stable fact his entire life, his belief in thoughts is lost. The practitioner explicitly sees the unstable, transient nature of thoughts and is deprived of this support.

The original, stable thoughts pass through stages: they fade with the loss of density, then a framework without a shell remains, then the framework degenerates into something like fast "breezes," then the "breezes" lose speed, calm down, and appear as condensations. These condensations also gradually decrease in size, losing "density" and "weight." The inner voice "turns off" somewhere after the "lake."

By roughly the end of the formless phase of practice, the properties of thoughts are as follows: "volume" becomes akin to the sound of blood flowing through vessels – a faint rustle that requires deliberate listening to be heard; "density" is comparable to a speck of down; the degree of impact is reduced to a minimum – the thought no longer fills the field of perception, but arises as a subtle, blurred condensation at its periphery.

In the completion phase, the act of observing mental activity in consciousness loses its meaning: the observer and the observed merge, what is observed is indeterminately nothing. The activity that is still present belongs to the category of "determinately nothing" – there is no movement of the mind, but there is an echo of bodily processes with an intensity approximately at the level of thermal noise.

Both "nothings" are only nothing. The determinate "nothing" differs from the indeterminate in that it happens – as an extremely brief moment of perception. The moment of perception happens determinately, but has no duration and does not accumulate into a sequence. The completion phase consists of this moment, which has no trail of accumulation.

* * *

A distinctive feature of the practice is a sensation mentioned in the "Report": "an unusual, soft sensation arises in the body-consciousness, which is difficult to describe due to its simplicity and depth."

This resembles a soft, deep pleasure that does not lead to habituation. It is a simple sensation, yet it contains a great deal. It is difficult to find a suitable definition for it, so it is conditionally called "disinterested pleasure."

The sensation of "disinterested pleasure" arises when consciousness becomes aware of itself. This occurs when the practitioner begins to see the light in consciousness. The appearance of the light in the field of perception and the appearance of the sensation of "disinterested pleasure" are directly connected.

This sensation fills the entire body, sometimes completely, sometimes partially overlapping other bodily sensations.

Simultaneously with the sensation of "disinterested pleasure," a sweet-sour taste arises in the mouth. This taste is concentrated on the palate; it intensifies slightly if the tongue is pressed against the palate. At the same time, a slight coolness is felt and saliva with this sweet-sour taste is secreted. Simultaneously, something like a movement and outward pressure occurs in the forehead and, to a greater extent, on the crown of the head.

As practice progresses, consciousness becomes devoid of artifacts; the light of consciousness ceases to stand out against their background and becomes an everyday presence. The same happens with the sensation of "disinterested pleasure" and the sweet-sour taste in the mouth: they become part of the practitioner's daily life.

The light of consciousness can be illustrated with an example: if a photo's exposure is increased while its contrast is simultaneously reduced, the photo gradually becomes simply white. The process is analogous: as self-inquiry proceeds and artifacts dissolve, the space of consciousness loses its contrasting content and becomes simply white, like an overexposed photo.

Based on observations, this can be interpreted as follows: the light is the "visual" appearance of consciousness, "disinterested pleasure" is consciousness’s sense of itself, and the sweet-sour taste is the "taste" of consciousness.

In the early stages of practice, after crossing the "black lake," the practitioner loses sexual attraction – it irreversibly fades (extinguishes). The attraction does not disappear instantly, but over about a month to six weeks.

Gradually, the practitioner's dreams become increasingly dim. He discovers that during sleep, a memory of the practice (the rules) surfaces, and the practitioner begins to practice periodically while dreaming. He does not realize that he is asleep but simply performs point 3 of the practical method. Gradually, the clear boundary between sleep and waking erodes – all of this becomes the first sensory "layer" of perception. Practice in dreams does not always occur: during periods of fatigue, illness, or recovery, the practitioner does not dream.

At this stage, the practitioner sees the flow that passes through him and is him. Initially, the flow had a bluish tint; later, the tint disappeared, and the flow became colorless or simply white. The flow has the property of splitting (branching) into different parts of the body. The branches from the main flow cause various activities inherent to different parts of the body.

The splitting of the flow occurs due to obstacles (artifacts): obstacles divide the flow, directing its individual streams to different parts of the body. The elimination of artifacts eliminates the splitting of the flow. The flow passes from bottom to top in a single "channel." The single "channel" is located vertically, approximately from the tailbone to the crown of the head.

It sometimes happens that a branch from the main "channel" arises. The practitioner observes the branch; over some time (minutes, tens of minutes), it withdraws back into the main "channel," following the tendency not to split.

Later, dreams change their properties, are perceived as if through frosted glass, and take place in a space filled with diffuse light. Faintly perceptible movements are visible through the light.

As dreams were transformed, it turned out that posture matters. Sleeping on the left side or on the back is noticeably more saturated with activity, with movements

in consciousness. Sleeping on the right side is calm and transparent. In the area of the heart there is an observable region that manifests itself as the source of mental activity. Sleeping on the left side creates pressure on this area, and movement (activity) arises in the dream. The difference in activity (between the left and right side) is significant (several times).

* * *

The practical study of the flow led to the understanding that the living body is something like a lens that focuses consciousness into itself. The flow does not enter the body from somewhere outside but is a concentrate of what is already there. Thus, one possible interpretation of the practical experience: consciousness is a direct property of space. This is a working premise.

Consciousness is a process of whole and unstructured (non-discrete) self-knowing. The process implies dynamics, hence the term "flow" is used.

It follows from the premise that the flow of consciousness is inseparable from the body: consciousness is not created by the processes of the body itself, nor is it borrowed from the surrounding space, but is already "contained" in the substance of which the body itself consists. Substance here is a condensate of space (the "material" aggregate state of space).

The organization of substance can be broken down into quantitative and qualitative. With quantitative organization, mass increases (the amount of substance). With qualitative organization, the organization of that mass grows more complex.

The qualitative organization of substance into a body, and the various processes that emerge from that organization, concentrate the living process of consciousness, manifesting what is already present as a property of space: consciousness is a natural and fundamental property, but it manifests gradually (concentrates) as the organization of substance becomes more complex.

If we unfold the working premise, the following emerges: as the dynamic (living) organization of substance becomes more complex – structures, processes, algorithms, the network of interconnections – the concentration of consciousness increases. Perhaps a stone also possesses consciousness, but in a very dispersed form due to the simplicity of the stone's structure. As the complexity of organization increases, the ability to self-replicate appears, along with metabolism, reactions to stimuli (feedback) in simple organisms and plants. In animals, the flow of consciousness is even denser: a central nervous system appears, reflexes, emotions, memory.

In humans, due to even more complex organization, the flow of consciousness exceeds a certain critical magnitude and becomes sufficient for consciousness to notice itself: first as a doer, and then as the absence of the doer.

An intermediate conclusion from the working premise is as follows: consciousness is not a new entity nor a special substrate; consciousness is not binary (either present or absent) – it is a manifestation of a natural property of space, expressed in varying degrees of concentration (a gradient of the property).

* * *

The flow of consciousness in the body has a tendency to be in a single "channel" – this tendency makes the flow laminar. Any turbulence or artifact (obstacle) in the main flow is immediately noticeable and subject to reverse transformation (return) into the flow.

Due to the flow's tendency toward unity, the practitioner does not seek interaction with the surrounding world. He does not avoid interaction but reduces it. Interaction with the human part of the surrounding world is like traversing severely rugged terrain. This inevitably deprives consciousness of laminarity, requiring strength and time for restoration. The practitioner performs only those actions that are minimally necessary. This is dictated not by preferences, but by the properties of consciousness-body.

Practice is not controlled but self-regulates, flowing as a balancing act at a moving point of equilibrium. Equilibrium arises naturally, from the fact that life and the practice of self-inquiry are not separate.

In the course of practice, the practitioner's lifestyle has changed significantly. He has lost almost everything he once had: work, property, most relationships, etc. The practitioner ceased to invest energy in maintaining his former lifestyle. Without effort, the framework of his former life collapsed; the flow of events swept away the remnants of the structure.

Left without means, the practitioner tried to engage in income-generating activities (skills and knowledge are present). However, he discovered that he has neither interest nor incentives to pursue them – the mechanisms that create involvement in human activity do not work in him. Without interest and a willingness to play roles, any participation in human activity ceases on its own. The practitioner does not engage in anything incompatible with him. Life itself decides what it will be.

Liberation from suffering occurs not as an acquisition of new qualities, but as a loss of the mechanisms that produce suffering. Along with these mechanisms, the transmission of suffering through the complex network of interactions is lost. The changes in lifestyle and the reduction of interaction with the surrounding world are a consequence of the loss of the mechanisms of suffering.

* * *

In Project Metamorphosis, less is written than is left unwritten. The project is a blueprint for a fishing rod and one variant of its assembly and use. The world is much more complex and diverse than its description. Reality is unattainable and always one step ahead of any theory, any interpretation, any understanding, no matter how complete it may seem. A theory or model that claims completeness creates the illusion of finality, and therefore such a theory or model is false.

The practitioner is not separate from the world but is its inseparable part, containing the entire world within himself. By right of inseparability, the practitioner has a legitimate opportunity to investigate himself and see the entire world. At its limit, such self-inquiry does not give the researcher any advantages but leads to the completion of a cycle that once began by a chance coincidence of circumstances.

Having seen the picture of being, the practitioner is deprived of the ability to speak about it. Any words are merely a crude interpretation, something extremely secondary in relation to what they are directed at. However, even if a more or less suitable array of words is selected, it will be of no use: experience is not transmitted by words, words do not change the practitioner, they do not lead to a direct perception of what the practitioner is, what the world is. The simplest solution in such a situation is the transmission of a tool, by means of which any person can see everything for themselves.

One of the issues to which very superficial attention is paid in Metamorphosis is the inheritance of imprint layers. Through a complex network of interactions, they become a kind of condensation nucleus, around which the body-lens is formed.

Inheritance exists; however, the mechanism of inheritance itself and what exactly is inherited are quite difficult to describe. For such a description to be coherent, a "supporting framework" in the form of a cosmological model would be required, where the mechanism of inheritance takes its regular place like a gear taking its place in "its own" clockwork mechanism. Such a model-"support" implies combining facts and theories from different fields of science. The result would be something redundant and slippery (speculation): a mixture of the falsifiable and the unfalsifiable. Such a mixture is capable of destroying the structure of the entire project.

The mechanism of inheritance is useful in that, with its help, the practitioner can remember the reason for appearing in this world, remember past attempts to complete the cycle. This gives the opportunity to include the past in the current experience. However, such remembering has meaning only in the context of continuing self-inquiry – as a stage of practice, but not as an independent result. If self-inquiry has reached the inherited layers, then the remembering of past attempts will occur without cosmology and metaphors.

* * *

In the context of self-inquiry, the crisis is a manifestation of the structure’s instability. The crisis is not anthropomorphic – it contains no hidden meaning or message. It is not a punishment, not a retribution, and not a lesson, but a direct consequence of the structure having reached a critical mass and being unable to sustain itself: it presses on itself, approaching collapse (falling in on itself).

The crisis is not something external (an event or a phenomenon), but a consequence of the properties of that "i" structure that is experiencing the crisis. For the structure itself, it looks like a turning point (a fork or a bifurcation point): instability and load are felt physically, the question "what to do next?" arises. On one side of the fork is the retention of the accumulated; on the other is the loss of the accumulated with an unknown outcome.

If a crisis has begun, then most likely it will not exhaust itself on its own and will not be healed by time. The accumulated tension strives toward discharge.

The beginning of a crisis implies two probable ways out of it. The first: the complete or partial collapse of the "i" structure. The second: the transformation of the structure into a different state with different properties. There are also other, intermediate exits, but they are variations of the first (collapse): compromise, cosmetic repair. The intermediate variants are unstable and differ in

how quickly the outcome arrives: the mass of the "i" structure continues to increase due to "supports" and "patches"; stability does not increase. Due to the greater mass, a repeated crisis turns out to be more large-scale.

The crisis – both individual and more extensive – does not exist in isolation from the conditions where it matured and began: the crisis is conditioned by context. The scale of the context determines the scale of the crisis, but does not determine the method of its overcoming or the variant of the exit. Regardless of scale, each person passes through the crisis and emerges from it individually. Human society is not a collective organism, but a multitude of structurally related individualities.

The ways out of the crisis for society and for the individual person coincide. Both exits – collapse and transformation – are symmetric and have equal rights to be chosen.

However, this symmetry does not mean a symmetry of consequences. Collapse is the complete or partial disintegration, followed by the erection of the "i" structure on the same foundation. The cycle repeats. Transformation is the gradual dismantling of the entire "i" structure, the replacement of the foundation with another, one that excludes accumulation (of mass). The cycle ceases.

* * *

A foundation consists of the root premises or axioms at the very base of any structure or system. The entire construction rests and is built upon them; therefore, the foundation is usually invisible and most often accepted unconditionally. In the practice of self-inquiry, the foundation determines the potential of the entire practice and its route: where the practice can go, and where it cannot.

The foundation of practice does not provide ready-made answers; its function is to give the researcher the possibility of finding answers independently, without relying on anything else.

The answers found will always be incomplete: an answer only opens access to the next question. The incompleteness of answers is not a defect but a door: it gives the inquiry the possibility of going beyond its former limits, not allowing it to settle for intermediate results. Incompleteness here is not a limiter but a natural driving force (the asymmetry of being).

Example: the premise “I am not the body.” The body is present, one way or another; without the body, life does not happen. Therefore, the premise “I am not the body” is false. A practice of self-inquiry built on this premise has an unstable foundation and a short route. When the answer to the question “who am I?” is found, the practice closes in on itself and turns into a constant proof that “I am not the body, but that (the found answer).” The found answer is a closed self-persuasion with a false foundation at its base.

Acknowledging incompleteness – “I am the body too” – opens up space for inquiry: the body is not accidental and is inseparably connected with the “i”. This connection can be investigated, and one can discover what was previously invisible because the given was ignored or denied.

Thus, any determinate support – a concept or an authority – sooner or later turns out to be false. Concepts divide reality into parts, fragmenting it. Authority is an intermediary between the researcher and the subject of inquiry, working like a game of telephone. Therefore, no wisdom, opinions, or quotes from authoritative people can be used as a fundamental premise (support) for the individual practice of self-inquiry. The foundation can only be a process (procedure).

One can rely on a procedure that distorts neither itself nor the researcher. Such a procedure must not contain falsehood. The absence of falsehood puts an end to going in circles: it is a criterion of truth that creates neither dependency nor closed loops. This turns the focus by 180°: from the attitude toward the subject of inquiry to the quality of the researcher himself.

A person has a quality that fully satisfies this condition. It is a basic quality, available at any moment and in any place. It requires no belief and can be used as a stable foundation for the practice of self-inquiry, possessing the maximum possible potential. This quality is honesty.

Honesty is the absence of fear and falsehood.

* * *

Falsehood

The flow of being is the given.

The flow of being is isotropic – it contains no privileged streams. A human is part of the flow, and without exception lives through everything that happens in life. This means that all possible events happen to a human, including those that are difficult to live through, both physically and psychologically. Difficulties activate the survival mechanism – a doer arises. Among other things, such a doer engages in evaluating what is happening and making efforts in various attempts to create a different "given," preferable to the doer – a false one.

Falsehood is local and is confined to the doer. Falsehood is an effort of the doer that distorts the perceived given. The resulting outcome requires control and effort to counter the inevitable pressure of contradictions. The results accumulate and gradually become the "body" of the doer – the costly work of maintaining the "body" turns into background, unconscious processes. The "body" of the doer is the interpreting filter.

Honesty cannot be defined positively – it is an absence. Honesty begins automatically where the efforts to maintain the local distortion of the given cease. Therefore, honesty, as a procedure of discernment, introduces no distortions – absence does not require effort to arise, to be protected, or to be maintained.

* * *

Intensity of Practice

Any investigation or study (of a discipline, a language, etc.) requires the application of effort. The distinction between the practice of self-inquiry and, for example, the study of physics lies in the properties of the subject under

investigation. A physics textbook is passive: it does not engage compensatory mechanisms to avoid discomfort, does not react to the reader as an existential threat, does not generate loss of interest, doubt, or sudden fatigue, and does not send the reader off in search of a "more better" textbook.

The subject of self-inquiry is the structure of the human "i". This structure has boundaries and expends energy on maintaining and defending them. The structure of the "i" actively resists investigation – this is a threat to its existence. The structure of the "i" is extremely adaptive and capable, up to a certain degree, of absorbing (assimilating) the practitioner's efforts directed toward its investigation. Applying effort at 50% and at 95% is equally futile for self-inquiry: the expended energy will be absorbed, transformed, and used by the structure of the "i" for its own defense.

The intensity of applied effort at the initial stages is decisive. Overcoming the threshold of resistance and the adaptive tricks of the "i" is possible only at an intensity of effort close to the maximum possible in each current situation. This condition is binary: either this way, or it will not work at all. Half-measures will not work due to the properties of the subject under investigation.

The intensity of executing the practical method prior to the first noticeable result (the change in the properties of thoughts) was sustained at the limit of available strength: 5-7 hours a day over a total duration of approximately 8-9 months. Time was not planned or set aside specially; the execution of the method occurred directly in the flow of everyday events, in every available minute. 5-7 hours is the total time of all fragments of practice per day.

The 8-9 months of the preliminary stage (before the start of the active phase) included experimentation with the practical method. The method described in the "Report" has been verified and is ready for use. The execution of an already prepared method can reduce the preliminary stage by approximately half – to 3-5 months (the time spent on trial and error is subtracted).

The maximum possible intensity is also useful in that it manifests self-pity in the practitioner at the very early stages. Self-pity appears in periods of intense fatigue and despair, when the practitioner is ready to give up everything. The manifestation of self-pity helps to discover its source.

In the active phase, average intensity decreases due to the peculiarities of the phase: "rollbacks," "dark nights," etc. However, on days when it was possible, the execution of the practical method amounted to 4-8 hours a day.

Overcoming the threshold of resistance does not mean that practice proceeds without difficulty from that point on. The structure of the "i" will resist as long as it exists. A marked change in practice occurs after crossing the "black lake." After the "lake," active resistance ceases, but inertial resistance remains in those areas of consciousness that have not yet been transformed.

As one advances in practice, its character changes: what previously required effort becomes everyday life. By approximately the end of the formless phase, an inversion occurs: now effort is required for what was everyday life before the beginning of the practice of self-inquiry. Practice does not end; its vector changes.

* * *

In the context of self-inquiry, knowledge (understanding) is not the acquisition of new information, but the loss of ignorance.

Consciousness, as the main subject of inquiry, cannot be positively defined: it is neither an object nor a process measurable by conventional methods. However, such an indeterminate subject can be investigated by itself, without involving additional means.

In the process of self-inquiry, it is discovered that, despite the diverse content, consciousness contains only consciousness. The content consists of the same consciousness, but in a different state of aggregation. Like ice floating in water.

In the notes, there is a mention of the light of consciousness. The light appears when the "solid" state of aggregation of consciousness is locally transformed into a formless primordial state. This empty primordial state is perceived as light – consciousness notices itself, discovers itself as light (within itself). Simultaneously with this, the sensation of disinterested pleasure and a taste in the mouth appear.

The light of consciousness is visible as long as there is a contrast with the "dark," unexplored areas where consciousness is still in its "solid" form (artifacts). As the inquiry progresses, as the artifacts are transformed (their state of aggregation changes), they disappear. The light of consciousness fills the previously "dark" areas, the contrast disappears – the light becomes a natural background and is no longer distinguished as a phenomenon. Such an everyday natural background is beyond form and action: it does not need support, it does not need to be known, remembered, or believed in.

The light of consciousness and other phenomena are not the goal of practice, but technical indicators (road signs) of the practice.

Knowledge (understanding) can be partial, complete (conditionally), and not-knowing (so-called ignorance).

Partial knowledge is visible and can be defined. The determinacy and visibility of partial knowledge stem from its incompleteness and its contrasting prominence against the background of the "dark" unexplored areas of consciousness that the researcher has not yet reached. Partial knowledge is such because of the mixture of explored areas of consciousness with unexplored ones.

Complete (conditional) knowledge is the absence of artifacts in consciousness and cannot be defined (is indefinable). In the absence of artifacts, there are no hidden areas in consciousness. Complete knowledge is homogeneous, invisible, serves as background, and does not stand out in contrast – it is consciousness in its originally empty, formless state of aggregation. In complete knowledge, the researcher knows nothing – the distance between the knower and the known is absent.

Complete knowledge is complete only conditionally, because it is limited by the framework (conditions) of living, individual practice. Incompleteness is conditioned by the living body of the researcher. The body is a given and the initial conditions (entry point); it has needs, limitations, and peculiarities; without it, self-inquiry will not happen. The body is like a cylindrical lens focusing consciousness into itself. At the same time, the light of consciousness does not come from somewhere; the body itself shines into itself and focuses the light of space-consciousness, of which it consists.

Complete knowledge is free space-consciousness; complete ignorance is the same space, but in a "solid" form, without gaps. Complete knowledge and complete ignorance are symmetrical and homogeneous: on the one hand, the homogeneity of unfilled space; on the other, the homogeneity of filled space.

A researcher who lacks the living experience of free space-consciousness may mistake a concept (form) for its absence, and one-off insight-events for liberation from form. This is possible as long as a stable gap does not appear in the "solid" filling of consciousness – the "cocoon" cracks, and through this gap consciousness notices itself. Thus, ignorance turns into partial knowledge. Now the researcher clearly sees this and can contrastingly distinguish the explored from the unexplored.

Accumulation and loss are different phases of the same process. Accumulation requires activity: protection, confirmation, maintenance, reinforcement, and the one who does all this. Loss has completely different properties: it needs neither protection, nor maintenance, nor the investment of effort, and has no doer.

The loss of ignorance is the transformation of the "solid" form-structure that closes free space from itself by itself. Loss is not the recognition of something specific, not a movement toward something, but the release of what already is.

Unconditionally complete knowledge is unattainable. Only different degrees of ignorance are attainable.

The completion of practice occurs with the death of the body. Death is the event horizon of life.

* * *

All that the practitioner possesses is understanding. This must be given away. Understanding must be packaged in the form of a gesture of non-addressed help and released into the flow of life.

Such a gesture simultaneously performs two distinct actions. First: the flow of life picks up and carries the gesture of help to whoever needs it. Second: the gesture liberates the practitioner – the reason for which the practitioner appeared in this world ceases; he ceases to be a node in the complex network of interactions.

Regarding the first action. The recipient is unknown; the practitioner does not know and cannot know the result – life itself will take care of it. The practitioner performs only his part of the action.

Regarding the second action. The practitioner must find and implement a non-trivial solution to the paradox: to fully give away understanding and not leave himself as a pointing monument. What the found solution will be, in what form understanding is given away – depends on the practitioner himself, on his inherent predispositions and qualities. The solution to the paradox is individual.

What matters is the quality of the gesture and other properties. The gesture must be profitless and transparent in due measure; it must not point to itself; it must not be manipulative and/or intrusive – this would devalue the gesture. The action must be minimally necessary and, at the same time, complete – containing all understanding in a concentrated form. Such is the nature of the flow of life: a tree gives away a seed, which contains the tree within itself, receiving nothing in return, not knowing what will happen next. The great within the small.

The "teacher syndrome" can manifest itself in any phase of practice. The "syndrome" relies on a legitimate, natural foundation: the offering of help and the transmission of understanding are built into the structure of being – it is a necessity, like passing a relay baton: a cause passing itself into its effect. This necessity can be appropriated by the remnants of the practitioner's i-filter at different stages of the practice of self-inquiry. Help turns into a disguise, used for the self-preservation of the i-filter and for obtaining benefit. Therefore, the question of "teaching" is highly ambiguous, lacks clearly defined boundaries, and requires attentive consideration.

Probable consequences for the practitioner: an unexplored lacuna remains – the role of "teacher." The role deprives the action of functional completeness: it preserves what should be given away. An incomplete action does not liberate the practitioner from the complex network of interactions – the relay baton has not been passed. The mechanism of inheritance leaves a preserved residue of the i-filter for the next cycle of practice.

The prevention of the "teacher syndrome" is the continuation of the practice of self-inquiry until the practitioner's death.

There is no one to evaluate the functionality of the action: in this world there are no "completed" ones, no experts in this area; all the living are equally unfinished and still in process.

Life is irreversible: it is not possible to return from beyond the event horizon of life and redo things. The action – passing the relay baton – is done "blindly," even if it seems that there is a semblance of determinacy and control. There is no possibility to find out the result and make a correction.

About the project

On the surface of this world, stones are found. If you find a pair of stones with certain properties and strike them against each other, sparks will fly. If you place tinder in the path of the sparks – it will catch fire. Burning tinder and dry sticks – you get a campfire. On a campfire, you can boil water. The stomach does not hurt from it, as it hurt from "raw" water.

The project does not claim to know the composition of the stones or to understand microbiology. The project has a practical orientation: "making a fire" for "boiling water."

The project was created retrospectively, after the "water boiled." There was no plan; the project arose spontaneously. At every stage of practice, around every turn, there was only the unknown – the practice proceeded "by touch," through trial and error. Along the way of self-inquiry, notes were made. Later, they were collected together, gradually taking the form of what is called project Metamorphosis.

In the project, necessity and fatigue from the pain "in the stomach" are mixed in equal measure.

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